PART IV · HARMONY · 11

Chords under a melody

The melody is the singer; the chords are the band. To choose a chord for each bar, look at the melody's main notes and pick the snowman holding them.

THE SECRET

Look at the melody's main notes, then pick the snowman that holds them.



I



IV



V

C	D	E	F	G	A	B
I, IV	V	I	IV	I, V	IV	V

Which snowman holds the tune's main notes?

Every note of C major lives in I, IV or V. C and G live in two: let your ear choose.
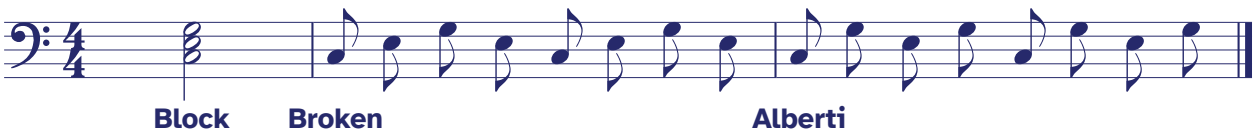
1. Look at the **main notes** of the bar: the long ones, and the ones on beats 1 and 3.
2. Find the snowman that holds them: **I, IV or V**.
3. Play that chord in the left hand while the right hand plays the tune.

Twinkle, Twinkle, with its chords



C C G G sit in I (C); A A in IV (F), then G in I; F F in IV, E E in I; D D in V (G), and the last C in I. The chord changes halfway through bars 2, 3 and 4.

Three ways to play the chord in the left hand



Block: all three at once. Broken: one at a time, up and down. Alberti: low, high, middle, high, named after Domenico Alberti, who loved it.

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EXAMPLE

Choose the chord: E D C D | E E E

E D C D | E E E

red = beats 1 and 3

1. **Bar 1:** the main notes are E and C (beats 1 and 3).
2. **E and C** both live in I.
3. **Bar 2:** E E E lives in I too.

Both bars take **I** (C). That is the start of Mary Had a Little Lamb.

GAME

Pick the snowman
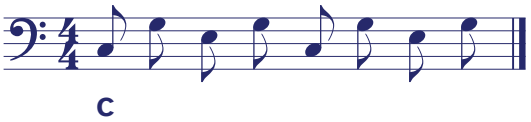
F A F A D B G B G E C E

1 2 3

Each bar is in C major. Which snowman holds its notes: I, IV or V?

Answer: 1 IV (F A C) · 2 V (G B D) · 3 I (C E G).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Left hand: C G E G, over and over.

That is the Alberti bass on the C chord. Keep it going while you hum Twinkle, then try it on F (F C A C) and G (G D B D).

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545: the left hand



The opening left hand is an **Alberti bass**: C G E G is just the C chord, broken into low, high, middle, high; D G F G is G7 (G B D F, without the B). Mozart wrote it an octave higher, starting on middle C.

Try it. Play this left hand alone, then add the famous tune: C, E G, B, C D C.

THINK OF IT Like picking a coat for the weather: when the tune changes, change the chord.

TRAP

- × Choosing a chord for a passing note: use the main notes (strong beats, long notes).
- × Playing the left hand louder than the tune: the melody is the star, the chords are the stage.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 92 · Cadences p. 113

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 11 · Online: Library › Chords